been told you don't look old or mature enough in some tests," she notes. Ananya looks at Alia Bhatt as an inspiration, someone who faced similar reactions early on, only to make an impression with her dramatic chops. Adds Ananya, "I want to use that vulnerability as a strength. It is not just about looks but also how you carry yourself."

To grow, she recognises she has to walk the tightrope and juggle between "quiet, more heartfelt films" and the big commercial films like *Dream Girl* and *Pati Patni aur Woh*. "Acting is a lot about opportunities that come to you and people who give you a chance to do something different," she says. In 2024, Ananya gets to do that in Vikramaditya Motwane's next, which unlike her other films will rest on her shoulders. "I am someone who is always seeking validation, and he gives no sign of it on set," she says of Motwane. He did end up giving some in a post on Instagram after he wrapped up the shoot.

Filmmakers like Motwane, Shakun Batra and Arjun Varain Singh are exposing Ananya to world cinema. For *KGHK*, she watched Greta Gerwig's *Frances Ha*, Ben Stiller's *Reality Bites* and the series *High Fidelity*. "I know I will get trolled for this, but I only watched *Godfather* three years ago," says Ananya, who grew up on the films of Karan Johar and Zoya Akhtar. Now that she has "tasted blood", she says she "can't settle for anything less. I need depth, meat when it comes to roles". And Ananya the hunter is just getting started. ■

–Suhani Singh

CINEMA

A Tender Thriller

Director ***Sriram Raghavan*** *talks about his latest film, the romance thriller* Merry Christmas

Q. How did you find the French novel *Le Montecharge* from which *Merry Christmas* is adapted?
Earlier, I'd spend Sunday mornings walking through the streets of Churchgate and Fort [in Mumbai] and buy books off footpaths and eventually see a film. That practice is gone as the culture has. Now, I buy books online. What I liked about this was that it's a very tender story but about crime. It was nice to break away from the twist-turn format of *Andhadhun*.

Q. Vijay Sethupathi has drawn acclaim for his performance in the film. What is it about him as a performer that establishes a connection with audiences?
He goes by the moniker Makkal Selvan, which translates to People's Treasure. He is one-on-one and down-to-earth with everybody he meets. He's curious about people and lives. So there's an immediate connect.

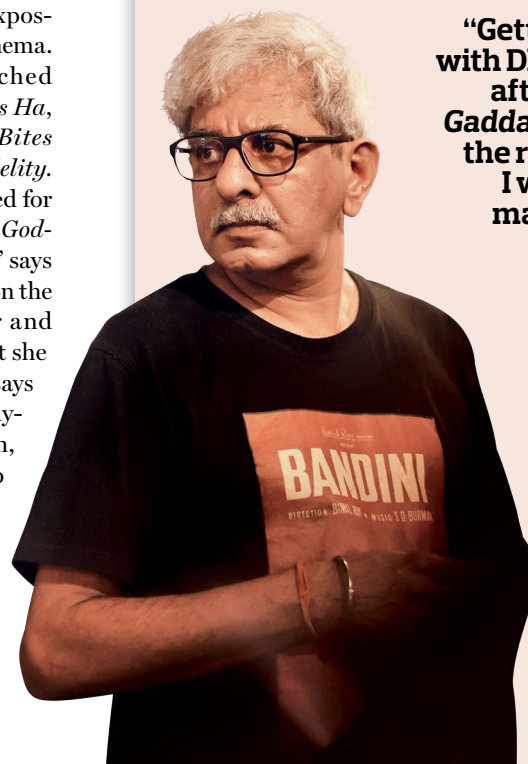
Q. One senses there's been a change of perception of you since *Andhadhun*. Is it easier to get actors now?
The other day my vegetable seller said you seem familiar and asked "*Kya karte hain* [what do you do)]?" It's not easy to get actors for odd stories but, yes, I do get occasional calls and texts from them. It's good to know that XYZ is there if I want to reach out [for a part].

Q. Cinephiles keep revisiting your films and trying to decipher them, like in the case of *Ek Hasina Thi*. There's also the label of desi Hitchcock.
There's too much hyperbole. I should not believe everything that's written about me. Most of it comes from people who want to become filmmakers. When I was getting into filmmaking in the late 1990s, I'd look up to Ramu [Ram Gopal Varma]. He was our God.

Q. You make films that are true to your sensibilities. How do you marry that to commercial success?
Conventional logic would be that after *Andhadun*, I could get a bigger star. I'm not thinking like let's write something for them. For them, too, it is difficult to reconcile and do something that's totally different and doesn't guarantee returns. I am not here to expand an empire. It has to be an interesting story that works for me.

Q. Tell us about your next, *Ikkis*.
It's the story of the martyr Arun Khetarpal, to be played by Agastya Nanda. It has been delayed a few times but [getting to work with] Dharamji [Dharmendra] again after *Johnny Gaddaar* was one reason why I wanted to do it. I knew he'd be a perfect fit. It was also an adventure to do a new genre. I'm trying to remove the stress of budgets and production. I saw *Oppenheimer* and thought, what a wonderful way of structuring a tale. With *Ikkis*, there's so much information and research and the challenge has been how to bring it all together. ■

–with Suhani Singh



"Getting to work with Dharamji again after *Johnny Gaddaar* was one of the reasons why I wanted to make *Ikkis*"

DEADLY ENDEARMENT
A poster of *Merry Christmas*

